

CORE FORMULA

Civil opener + relevant fact + clear next step or limit. -> Brief: one short paragraph. Informative: facts, not counter-claims. Friendly: civil language, no contempt. Firm: a clear end, boundary, or action. -> Thanks for the update. The report was sent at 4:15 pm yesterday. I will resend it now, and use email for any further changes. -> I understand this is frustrating. The meeting is Thursday at 10 am. I will discuss the agenda in the meeting, not by text. -> I hear that you disagree. My decision remains the same. I am available to discuss implementation steps, not personal accusations.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Write three sentences: one civil opening, one factual answer, one firm next step.

BEST FOR

- Hostile emails, texts, and chat messages
- Inaccurate claims that need one factual correction
- Logistics inside a tense or high-conflict relationship
- Workplace misunderstandings where a calm written record matters
- Customer or stakeholder complaints that mix facts with accusations
- Co-parenting, committee, neighbourhood, or admin threads
- Public or semi-public comments where your tone will be judged
- Repeated bait, where longer explanation has already failed

PHRASE BANK

Civil openers · Short opening acknowledgements

- "Thanks for sending this."
- "Thanks for the update."
- "I have read your message."
- "I understand this is important to you."
- "I can see this has been frustrating."
- "I hear that you disagree."

Informative facts · State the record cleanly

- "The meeting is scheduled for 3 pm on Thursday."
- "The document was sent to the shared folder yesterday at 4:15 pm."
- "The decision was based on the criteria in the policy."
- "The current deadline is Friday at 5 pm."
- "The next step is to send the revised version by Tuesday."
- "I am available for the logistics, not for a debate about motives."

Friendly bridges · Civil without over-pleasing

- "I appreciate you checking."
- "I hope this clarifies the practical next step."
- "Thanks for keeping the logistics moving."
- "I want this to stay workable for both of us."
- "I am glad to keep communication clear."

Firm closes · A clear end or boundary

- "I will not discuss personal accusations by email."

- "I will respond to new information, not repeated allegations."
- "Please send any practical changes by Friday."
- "This is my final reply on this point unless something new comes up."
- "I will continue through the agreed channel."
- "If the tone stays personal, I will pause and return to logistics only."

Workplace & customer replies · Work, meeting, client, ticket

- "Thanks for raising this. The agreed scope is the March report and the client deck. I will send both by 2 pm; further scope changes go through the project lead."
- "I understand you are unhappy with the decision. The approval process was completed on Monday. I am available to discuss implementation steps."
- "Thanks for flagging the review issue. The current draft was submitted yesterday and is still open for corrections. Please add specific edits in the document by 4 pm."
- "I understand the delay is frustrating. Your replacement order is scheduled for dispatch tomorrow, and the tracking link will arrive by 6 pm. I will update this ticket when dispatch is confirmed."
- "I can confirm the invoice covers May only. Please send any questions about June as a separate item by Friday."

Social & family replies · De-escalating a personal thread

- "I hear that you are upset. I can help with the appointment on Friday at 10 am. I am not available for blame by text."
- "Thanks for letting me know. I will bring the forms at pickup. I am not going to discuss blame by text."
- "I understand this is stressful. I can take Dad to the Friday appointment at 10 am, and discuss anything broader when we are both calmer."
- "I hear that you are upset. The plan is 5 pm at Mum's. I am not going to revisit insults from the text thread."

Digital & public replies · Comments and semi-public threads

- "Thanks for commenting. The event starts at 6 pm and registration is free. For individual issues, please contact the organiser by email."
- "I understand the concern. The post has been updated with the correct date. I will leave further moderation to the page admins."
- "Thanks for checking. The event starts at 6 pm on Friday at the main hall, matching the registration page."
- "Thanks for flagging it. The details have been corrected. Anything further can go to the organiser directly."

High-pressure & repeated bait · Guarded, under fire, or looping

- "I have read your message. I will respond to the factual issue after reviewing the file. I will not respond to personal claims."
- "The urgent point is noted. The current decision stands until we receive new evidence. Please send that evidence in one email by noon."
- "I have answered the practical issue. The booking remains for Tuesday at 2 pm. I will respond again if there is new scheduling information."
- "The file was sent to the shared folder yesterday at 4:15 pm. I have resent the link below. Future document updates will stay in the shared folder."
- "I will keep this thread focused on delivery details and will not respond to personal character comments."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: That is unfair. I did read your notes, and you keep changing them. The project is not a mess — you are exaggerating.
Better: I read your notes. The current version includes the budget changes and timeline update. I will review the risk section next.
Best: Thanks for flagging the notes. The current version includes the budget and timeline changes; I will review the risk section by 3 pm and keep comments in the document thread so changes stay traceable.
- Weak: That is ridiculous and you know it. I helped all last month — you only remember what supports your story.
Better: I understand you are upset. I can help with the appointment on Friday. I am not available for insults by text.
Best: I understand this is stressful. I can take Dad to the Friday appointment at 10 am. I will stay on logistics by text and discuss anything broader when we are both calmer.
- Weak: Matches the heat and opens three new argument threads.
Better: States the relevant facts and drops the insult.
Best: Brief, informative, friendly, and firm — one civil line, one fact, one clear next step.

DECISION TREE

If The message did not actually require a reply.

Do not reply, or archive and monitor. Silence is a legitimate BIFF move.

If There is immediate safety, legal, HR, or abuse risk.

Preserve the record and use the proper escalation pathway; use BIFF only for the minimum necessary contact.

"I will follow this up through the appropriate channel."

If The person wants care, not a fight.

Switch to validation, reflective listening, or NVC / OFNR instead of containment.

"That sounds really hard. Tell me what would actually help."

If The message carries bait, accusation, hostility, or false claims.

BIFF fits. Pick the one reply-worthy issue — a fact, decision, deadline, boundary, or next step — and answer only that.

"The revised deadline is Friday at 5 pm."

If It is a neutral request, not an attack.

Use the technique that fits the task instead: BLUF, a clean request, SBI, or Ask-Tell-Ask.

If Your draft runs long, defends your motives, or ends with no next step.

Cut it back to civil opener + fact + firm close before sending.

"Thanks for the update. [Fact.] [Next step.]"

SCENARIOS

Hostile workplace email

Acknowledge the flag, state the current status, and route edits to a traceable channel. — "Thanks for flagging the review issue. The current draft was submitted yesterday and is still open for corrections. Please add specific edits in the document by 4 pm."

Co-parenting logistics

Confirm the practical arrangement and name the channel boundary. — "I understand scheduling is important. Pickup is confirmed for 5 pm at the school entrance. I will keep this thread focused on logistics."

Customer escalation

Acknowledge the frustration, give the concrete next action and time, and promise an update. — "I understand the delay is frustrating. Your replacement order is scheduled for dispatch tomorrow, and the tracking link will arrive by 6 pm. I will update this ticket when dispatch is confirmed."

Public criticism

Correct the fact once, in the open, without defending your character. — "Thanks for checking. The event starts at 6 pm on Friday at the main hall. The post has been updated to match the registration page."

Family accusation

Acknowledge the feeling briefly, offer the concrete help, and decline the blame. — "I hear that you are upset. I can help with the appointment on Friday at 10 am. I am not available for blame by text."

Repeated bait or a demand to apologise

State that the practical issue is answered and set a condition for replying again. — "I have answered the practical issue. The booking remains for Tuesday at 2 pm. I will respond again if there is new scheduling information."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Immediate safety action is needed
- The person is asking for comfort, not attacking you
- You owe a fuller apology, repair, or explanation
- The problem needs a live conversation, not written compression
- The other party needs informed consent or detailed context
- The issue is complex enough that a short reply would mislead
- You are reaching for brevity in order to stonewall
- The matter should be escalated to a manager, mediator, lawyer, HR, or safety contact

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the hook

Take three hostile or baiting messages you have received. For each, underline the single sentence that actually needs a reply and cross out the accusations, sarcasm, and history.

Day 2 — Heat-strip rewrite

Pick one of those messages. Sort every sentence into fact-to-answer, accusation-to-ignore, feeling-to-acknowledge, or practical request. Draft a reply using only the fact, a brief acknowledgement, and a next step.

Day 3 — Three-sentence limit

Write BIFF replies to five different messages, each in exactly three sentences: civil opener, relevant fact, firm next step. Keep every reply under 90 words.

Day 4 — Remove the hooks

Write your honest first reply to a heated message, then delete character defence, blame history, sarcasm, repeated explanation, and any guess about their motives. Compare what remains to the original.

Day 5 — Firmness calibration

Take one boundary and write it three ways — too soft, too harsh, and clear-and-civil. Note the exact words that create weakness or aggression, and keep the clear version.

Day 6 — Observer test

Reread this week's replies as if a manager, mediator, judge, client, or family member will see them. Revise each until it reads steady, factual, and fair.

Day 7 — Live use

In a real tense thread, pause before replying, send one genuine BIFF response, and afterwards note whether it reduced sprawl and prevented a new argument.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I wait long enough that heat is not leaking into the message?
- Have I named the single reply-worthy issue and answered only that?
- Are these facts, not emotional counter-claims?
- Is the tone civil without over-pleasing or apologising for things I did not do?
- Is the boundary or next step clear, and does the last line close the loop?
- Would a neutral third party read this as reasonable — or should it be escalated instead?